A key official of the defence ministry reveals that the fact Rafale-Ms share high commonality with the IAF's Rafale fleet went in their favour. Inducting a new aircraft type, he adds, would have introduced complex maintenance and supply chain challenges; the Rafale-Ms leverage existing infrastructure, reducing costs for spares, repairs and inventory and adding to its operational performance.

COUNTERING THE CHINA-PAKISTAN THREAT

This synergy not only strengthens the navy's carrier strike group but also enhances India's deterrence against China's *Shandong* and *Fujian* aircraft carriers and Pakistan's advanced submarines and frigates. From 2020-2025, the China-Pakistan naval collaboration has strengthened their combined maritime capabilities. Pakistan's Type 054A/P frigates (Tughril-class) are Chinese platforms equipped with sophisticated radar systems, anti-ship missiles and air defence capabilities. Additionally, its Hangor-class submarines, based on China's Yuan-class Type 039A, are part of an eight-submarine deal, with deliveries expected by 2028. These submarines, featuring air-independent propulsion—that enable them to stay submerged for long periods—and Babur cruise missiles, enhance Pakistan's ability to conduct stealthy operations in the Arabian Sea.

MEAN MACHINE

Besides nuclear capability, the Rafale-M possesses specialised avionics, sensors and communication equipment for maritime operations and comes equipped with a variety of weapons systems

1,912
KMPH
Maximum Speed

1,000
KM
Combat Radius

ELECTRONIC WARFARE

SPECTRA
Integrated electronic countermeasures, including radar jamming, missile warning, infrared decoy systems

FRONT SECTOR OPTRONICS
Infrared search and track for passive target detection

RBE2-AA
Active Electronically Scanned Array (AESA) radar with 200 km detection range for air targets



CARRIER COMPATIBILITY

- » Folding wings to optimise deck storage
- » Anti-corrosion coating for maritime environments
- » Microwave Landing System (MLS)–precision carrier landing assistance
- » Reinforced airframe and landing gear for catapult-assisted takeoff and arrested recovery

As India asserts itself in the IOR, the Rafale-M's interoperability—the ability to operate in conjunction with other militaries—with platforms of allies like France and QUAD partners position it as a linchpin in countering the 'String of Pearls' strategy and Pakistan's Chinese-backed naval build-up. With China bolstering its carrier strike groups and deploying long-range naval aviation assets with an intent to project power far beyond its shores, the Rafale-M's technological edge will enhance deterrence, and ensure robust defence of Indian interests in contested maritime zones across the IOR. Regular Chinese patrols near critical Indian Ocean chokepoints, such as the Malacca Strait, combined with strengthened maritime partnerships with nations like Sri Lanka and Pakistan, coupled with its naval base in Djibouti and access to Gwadar Port, underscore the evolving threat landscape India must navigate.

A naval officer reiterates that the Rafale-M's technological superiority is crucial for countering the PLA Navy (PLAN). With its advanced AESA radar, SPECTRA electronic warfare and weapons package, the Rafale-M excels in fleet air defence, maritime strike, and area-denial operations that would enable it to neutralise Chinese carrier strike groups, long-range naval aviation assets and surface vessels. Its low-observable features enhance survivability against China's advanced air defence systems, ensuring India can maintain a qualitative edge over its J-15 fighters and future carrier-based aircraft.

At the same time, the Rafale-M's anti-submarine warfare capabilities and precision-guided munitions allow it to counter Pakistan's submarine threat, while its air-to-air combat prowess, bolstered by the Meteor missile, ensures air superiority over the Arabian Sea against the Pakistan Air Force's JF-17 and F-16 aircraft.

WHY THE RAFALE-M

Beyond its operational advantages, the Rafale-M aligns with India's broader strategic goals as a net security provider in the IOR. Its compatibility with India's aircraft carriers, INS *Vikrant* and the planned INS